

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Tanzania Education Corporation_Tanzania_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Tanzania Education Corporation (TEC)

Fellowship City

Makuyuni

Fellowship Country

Tanzania

Fellowship Start Date

07/14/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/12/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

STEM Teacher

What are your primary responsibilities?

This term, I teach five classes. My students are roughly the age of first-years through juniors in high school. I plan to add a class in 2023 of A-level students that are roughly 19. In those classes, I instruct computer literacy and programming. I am also in charge of a teacher development program as part of a partnership with Team4Tech. Aside from teaching, I am the main IT person and create projects for students to do to supplement learning. The IT work has consisted of configuring a new computer lab, installing OS and restrictions on all lab computers, and maintaining computer condition. At every school graduation (roughly 3 per year), a couple of student projects are presented at the ceremony.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

I was trained by the previous teacher in my role in unfamiliar programming languages, basic IT skills, and other work essentials. The platform was not structured or organized, however, which stressed me out early on. Unfortunately, we did not overlap for any teaching time so I needed to learn to teach here on my own.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

I go to my office in the computer lab around 9 AM every day. I will then start my day by following up on emails about new computer software or making requests to my supervisor if I have any. Then I will prep for my lesson that afternoon. Most of the time, I need to copy files to the school computers which requires a manual data transfer on USB drives. With the lesson ready, I then research future student projects and make sure I have material for my future project sessions. Project examples include a robot dog running on Raspberry Pi OS, bottle rockets, and using block coding to create VR worlds. At some point throughout the day, it's inevitable that a teacher will call me with technical difficulties. I frequently need to reinstall Microsoft Office on computers, change passwords, manage device installation restrictions, etc. Once the school day ends, I have open lab hours for students working on individual projects editing photos or creating beats. During that time, I assist with student activities and field countless questions about Wi-Fi access. In the evenings, I frequently have one-hour sessions dedicated to group projects such as those mentioned above.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

41

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

My biggest project success was leading the student group to assemble and present the robot dog at the Standard 7 graduation of the primary school affiliated with our secondary school. That project took countless hours of me troubleshooting Raspberry Pi OS, broken SD cards, internet connection, and monitor compatibility. Eventually, we had a successful graduation presentation, with which the administration was immensely pleased. I also took on the role of organizing and leading a three-hour workshop on Microsoft Office for teachers over the weekend. The schedule changed three times the day before. The administration decided that all three sessions would be back to back which was exhausting for me but the workshop was well received by teachers.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work in the back office of a spacious computer lab with eight tables all of which have four computers. My office is connected to the back of the lab and has space for my large desk and lockers with all lab materials. I also have an additional table to place project supplies that are currently in use. Overall, my office space is quite nice even if a bit stuffy. The office and lab have access to limited Wi-Fi.

To whom do you report?

My most direct supervisor is the Programs Director of TEC. She is based in Karatu which is about an hour from my location in Makuyuni but visits my school 1-2 times per week. We work together on designing the STEM program and our partnership with Team4Tech. She is my point person to share ideas and ask questions.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

We just discuss general goals for the TSSS STEM program, but yes.

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

I want to improve my class attendance. So far I've struggled to motivate students to come to class since my course is optional and does not have national exams. I hope to implement a robust teacher training program whether by hosting regular workshops or partnering with ICDL. I want to bring Starlink internet service to my school. I hope to excite more girls about STEM.

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Please provide more information on your response above.

My goals focus on three main topics. Two center around improving my classroom effectiveness and outreach to students who are not naturally interested in computer science. One hopes to equip teachers with the skills necessary to improve their use of technology in the classroom. The last strives to improve school infrastructure to increase the resources available for student learning.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

Karatu to Tumaini Junior School graduation where my students presented the robot dog. Arusha to visit Arusha Science, an A-level school teaching only STEM subjects.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response.

I am neutral on this point because my undergrad studies were not in computer science and I had no experience teaching before starting my role. When I signed my PiAf contract, I was to be a STEM co-teacher, instructing on topics I was familiar with (such as Python) and generating projects for students. However, my co-teacher handed in his notice two days later. Consequently, I was left to learn most of the material I teach in the month before classes began. I was never able to shadow a class of the previous teacher before beginning either. That said, I'm doing my best and learning the skills I need to be successful.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I fly direct from NYC to Nairobi on Kenya Airways then had a long layover before a short flight to Kilimanjaro International Airport on Precision. I found the flight plan on KAYAK but booked directly with Air Kenya for both flights. The cost was \$816.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I am still on a tourist visa and waiting to be approved for a resident and work permit.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I applied online for the tourism visa and TEC is helping me acquire a resident permit.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

I had my tourism visa before arrival

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

A tourism visa is \$100 and the work permit is \$1000.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

TEC covers the cost.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

I was almost denied entry to Kenya because of my extended tourism visa status. Now, I wait for a lawyer to push my resident permit application through the system.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Start it early and apply for the resident permit well before departure. Consult TEC throughout this process.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I received a TDAP booster, yellow fever, and typhoid fever vaccines. The cost was \$440 total.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

It was very difficult. I'm very isolated and felt lonely and jet-lagged that first week. I was also thrown straight into a full day of work within ten hours of my arrival and then worked a 12-hour day. I will help make sure the next person in my role has a smoother landing. I was appreciative that the previous teacher showed my his favorite local restaurants and introduced me to piki piki (motorbike) drivers. I will also advise my successor and strategies to prevent homesickness.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Yes, housing is provided at school and it's quite nice just extremely remote.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Rural

Please describe your living environment

Makuyuni is an hour and a half from Arusha. Tumaini Senior is a mile and a half from Makuyuni. The school is in the middle of the savanna, a beautiful but rural landscape. Elephants visit school during the dry season!

I have two rooms as part of my living space. One has a coffee table with chairs and a small kitchen with supplies and a fridge. The stove looks like an enlarged camping stove. The other room has my bed complete with a mosquito net and a bedside table. A bathroom is attached to my bedroom but the rooms above mine share an outdoor bathroom.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

Technically, you never need to leave school but you will want to because it's so isolated. Taking a boda boda into Makuyuni (the school is about 2km outside town) costs about \$0.40. The school also has a bus that runs to town in the evenings. There are no private car options available to town.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

Once in Makuyuni, you can take public transport to Arusha (about 1.5 hrs east) or Karatu (about 1 hr west). There is a school car that regularly runs to Karatu free of charge since the Tumaini Junior School is in Karatu. In Karatu, there is a house for TEC volunteers to stay without additional payment. Public transport by bus to Arusha is roughly \$1.80 and to Karatu is slightly less. The buses will always be crowded and hot but you get used to it quickly.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Since I arrived, the highs have been between 80 and 92 every day and the lows have been between 50 and 62 every day. It's incredibly dry and we wait for the rains to come soon. Due to climate change, the rainy season is shortening and the dry season (our current season) is growing much longer.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

At school, the dress code is "smart." For men, that means collared shirts, pants, and decent shoes every day. For women, that means skirts (pants are not allowed at school) and nice shirts or a dress with decent shoes. No one really wears shorts even beyond school. I have no trouble running in shorts and a t-shirt, however. I do avoid wearing short-short running shorts though.

How have you been spending your free time?

I run pretty much every day. I keep my journal up to date. I watch shows with friends from home on Teleparty. I call my family and friends every day. I enjoy reading. I write in my blog when I'm motivated. I watch soccer matches with other teachers. I travel when I feel up for an adventure on weekends. Life here is slow. You are in the middle of the savanna. I enjoy getting dinner with fellow teachers when the opportunity presents itself. I'm the only expat in my town but have befriended a few teachers at school. It's difficult to partake in conversation though because their English skills are limited, and they speak to each other exclusively in Kiswahili.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

My calls make me feel very connected to people at home. My friends and family have been very interested to hear how I'm doing. The PiAf fellow community has also been amazing in providing community through calls and in-person visits. At school, I also feel that I have good relationships with my community. Balancing my time between each group has been great to provide a range of different support systems.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

School is incredibly safe. I also am safe to walk around Makuyuni at night if I'm on the main roads. The biggest danger near school are elephants during the dry season. They can be extremely dangerous if they catch your smell.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

If I'm anywhere except Makuyuni, I never walk alone at night. I also keep my valuables secured in zipper pockets of bags when at all possible.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

No interaction with crime.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Makuyuni is safe as I've mentioned, and Tumaini Senior is even more secure with guards.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I don't remember my specific goals from orientation. I do think I wanted to establish meaningful relationships with students and that's happening slowly. I also recall hoping to become proficient in Kiswahili but feel I'm falling short of that goal so far. My working goals change almost weekly depending on the challenges I'm facing. Early on, I just wanted to survive the complications from my malaria meds. Then, I strove to learn the necessary CS to teach my classes. Now my goals center around improving my classroom effectiveness and helping leave positive organizational changes in my wake. This experience has had so many surprises that I'm not even sure my orientation goals would have been relevant.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

My biggest frustration has been related to inadequate organization and training. To this day, I'm still discovering computer passwords the previous teacher did not tell me. I also was never able to shadow one of his classes so learning to teach has been difficult. My own teaching weaknesses frustrate me because I don't feel I know how to manage the students well. Corporeal discipline is practiced here, so without any way to enforce my rules on students, they have little incentive to listen to me.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Anything I've missed I've been able to receive from TEC visitors. Obviously, you cannot acquire many things in Makuyuni but basic personal care items and foods are available.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I did my best to enter the culture with an extremely judgment-free mindset. To a large extent, I think I've been successful because I feel my perspective has broadened, and better understand the function of some major differences that make me uncomfortable. Witnessing the corporeal punishment at the school was a shock at first, but with time I've come to understand how the students understand the risk of their actions and such punishments are expected by parents. Although I do not engage, I accept these differences and do not judge. Other cultural differences are also hard to accept such as the hostility towards homosexuality and the lack of equality for women. I do my best to engage in productive conversation when these topics arise but never push. Part of dealing with culture shock is accepting that I cannot change societal attitudes. I also needed to time to get used to getting bothered on the street anytime I go into a town and children yelling at me when I run. These things happen. 99.9% of the time they are harmless. I learned to not let them bother me.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How much more difficulty is added to the fellowship in a rural post. The difficulty finding community beyond school has been immense, and the loneliness was crushing early on. However, I found my rhythms and have befriended teachers who I've traveled to nearby towns with. I don't have an expat community I engage with, but my PiAf cohort has been invaluable online and in person.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Teaching! Teaching has been immensely difficult because as a first-time teacher my classroom effectiveness was low. In addition, school culture here is incredibly different from the US. I tried to be nice early on since I was new and nervous, allowing the students to take advantage of my lack of rule enforcement. Now, I've finally come to realize that to teach here I must be strict. There is no way around it even if it is uncomfortable for me.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

Food. A laundry machine. Reliable internet.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

The wildlife. Low-stress colleagues. The stars at night.

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly in USD to my US bank account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Direct deposit

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$50.02	\$0.00	\$30.00	\$50.00	\$0.00	\$150.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$200.00	\$10.00	\$0.00	260.02
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

As I mentioned before, I think I underestimated the added difficulty of being in a rural, isolated post. I think having a breakout session for rural fellows and solo fellows would be really helpful. I also feel there was an overemphasis on safety. Of course, I need to be cautious and careful on a daily basis but there are more day-to-day life skills that could have been emphasized instead.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

Partially addressed above. I think it would also be helpful to have more country-specific information available. For example, what does public transport look like? What is the local diet? How do social norms differ? Maybe fellows in posts with predecessors got this information though.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

I think small group breakouts to revisit how our assumptions and expectations differed from actual experiences. Example topics could include food, isolation, culture, transport, etc. I also think it would be good to break into different affinity groups at some point to discuss how specific aspects of identity and position affect the experience. By position, I mean rural vs urban, solo, region, or type of work. On a different note, I think it would also be fun to have a whole group session on how to make the most of the fellowship and hear from others about what they've done to maximize their time in their role and on the continent as a whole!